Priyabrata Sahoo
CSBS
241401072

Exp 2: Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface.

1. Introduction

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based, enterprise-grade low-code application development platform that allows users to design, build, and deploy business applications with minimal hand-written code. It provides an integrated suite of tools for data management, process automation, user interface design, integration, governance, and analytics.

Before constructing specific application modules in subsequent experiments, it is necessary to establish an operational Zoho Creator account and navigate its administrative and development consoles. This experiment explores the platform's core architecture and documents each primary interface component, detailing its definition, administrative purpose, and practical enterprise use case.

2. Zoho Creator Low-Code Architecture

The Zoho Creator low-code architecture is a platform-based architecture that allows users to build applications with minimal coding. It consists of multiple layers: the user interface layer, which provides forms, pages, reports, and dashboards for users to interact with the application; the application layer, which contains workflows, automation scripts (Deluge), and business logic; and the data layer, which manages data storage, relationships, and data access policies.

Behind the scenes, Zoho Creator manages server infrastructure, database allocation, security compliance, and cross-platform compatibility (web and mobile), enabling developers to focus exclusively on solution design and process logic.

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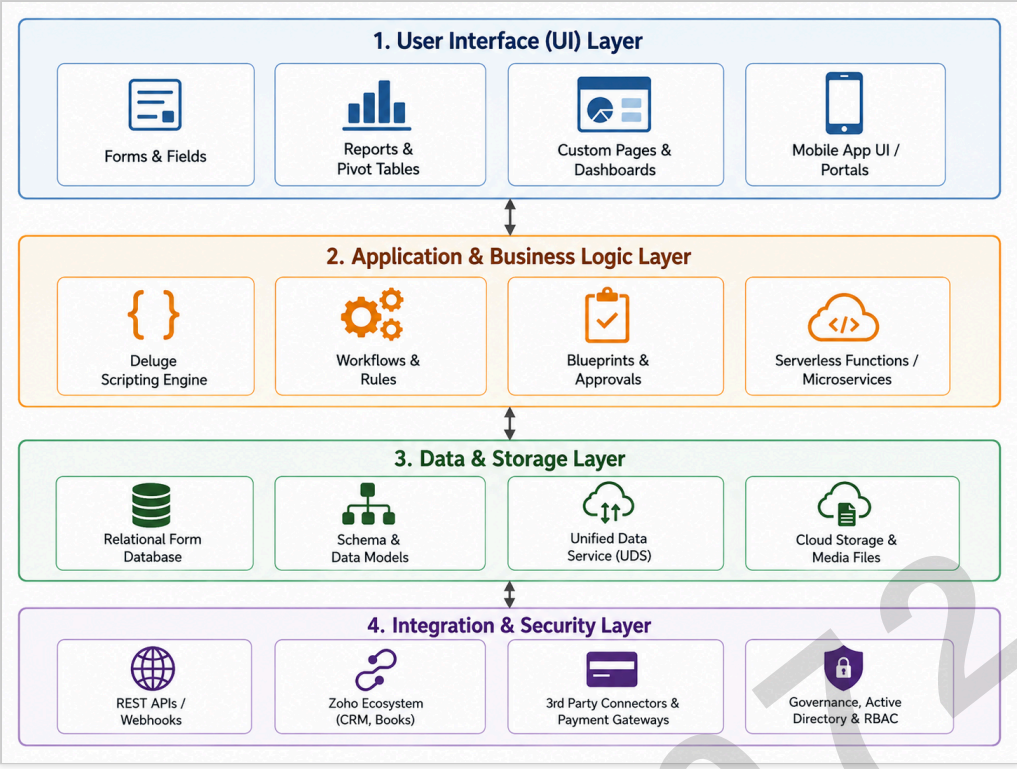


Figure 1: Zoho Creator Account & Console Architecture Overview

3. Platform Components

The Zoho Creator interface organizes its toolkit into three central categories: **DEVELOP**, **DEPLOY**, and **MANAGE**. This structure facilitates the oversight of an application's full lifecycle, encompassing design, deployment, user administration, and system settings. Below is an overview of the key platform modules and their primary functions:

3.1 Application

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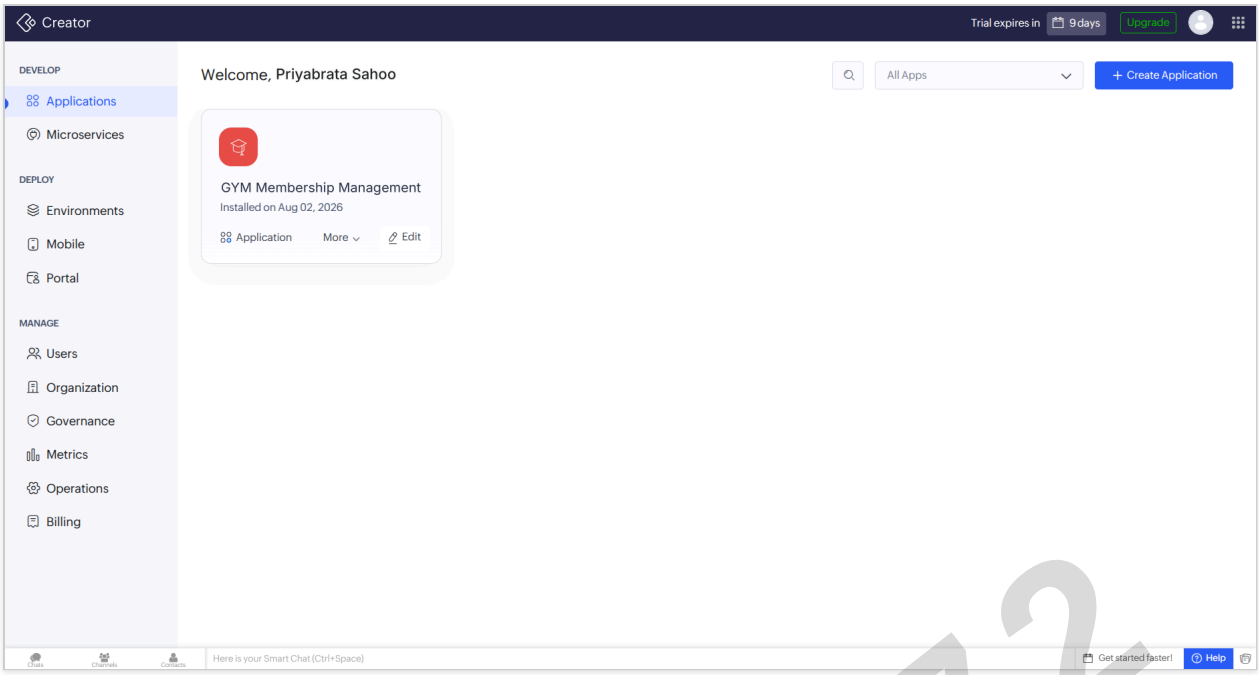


Figure 2: Application workspace in Zoho Creator

Definition: The core workspace where applications are created, customized, and configured using visual builders for forms, reports, workflows, and pages.

Purpose: Serves as the primary development environment for structuring database schemas, designing user interfaces, and writing Deluge automation scripts.

Use Case: Designing a custom "Student Information Management System" containing forms for enrollment, reports for timetables, and fee transactions.

3.2 Microservices

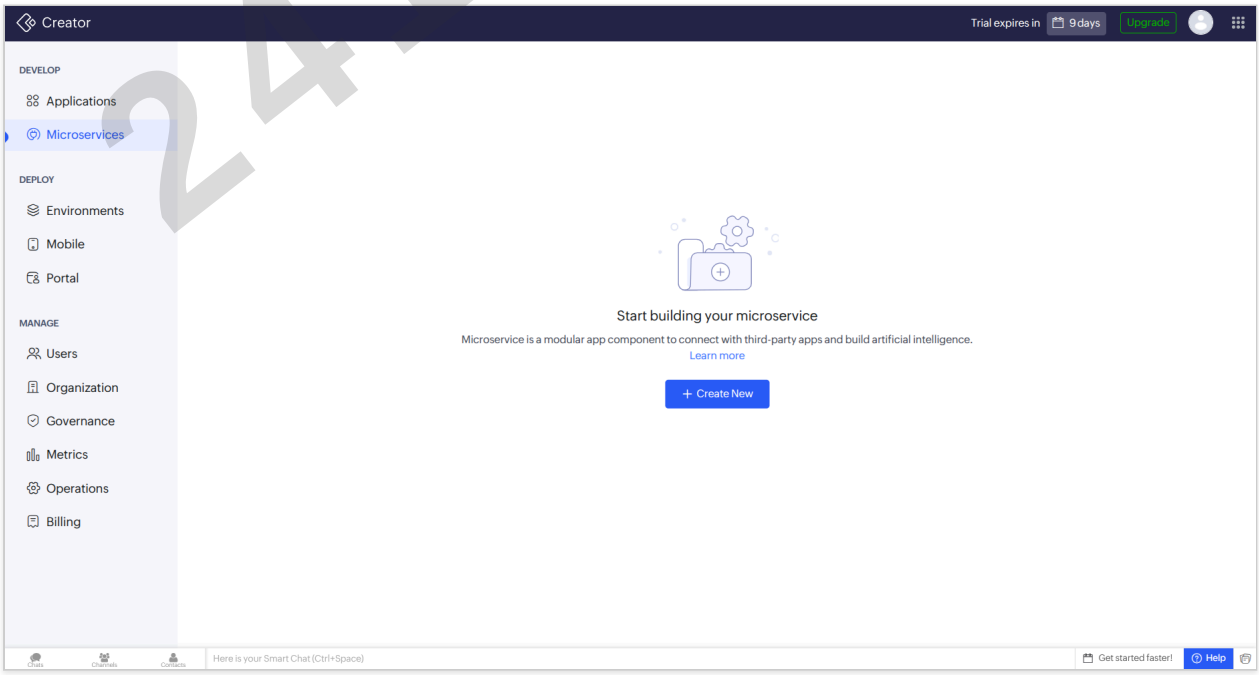


Figure 3: Microservices screen in Zoho Creator

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Definition: An area dedicated to constructing modular service components, external integrations, and AI-driven capabilities.

Purpose: Enhances base application functionality by separating complex backend operations, custom API connections, and machine learning logic.

Use Case: Building a microservice to integrate an automated OCR scanner that reads text from student ID cards uploaded to the system.

3.3 Environments

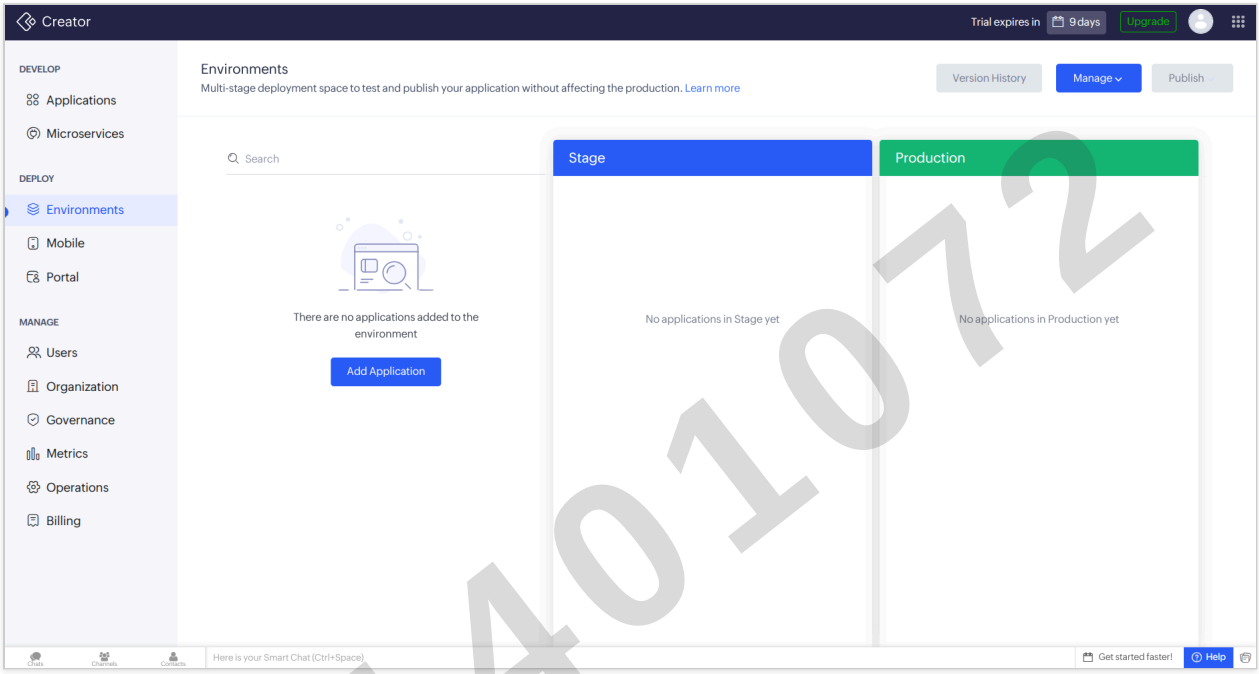


Figure 4: Environments screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: A staged deployment system featuring separate spaces for testing and live operations.

Purpose: Minimizes disruption by providing a safe area for developers to validate code changes before releasing them to active users.

Use Case: Verifying an automated grading script in the Stage environment to confirm accuracy before updating the live Production app utilized by instructors.

3.4 Mobile

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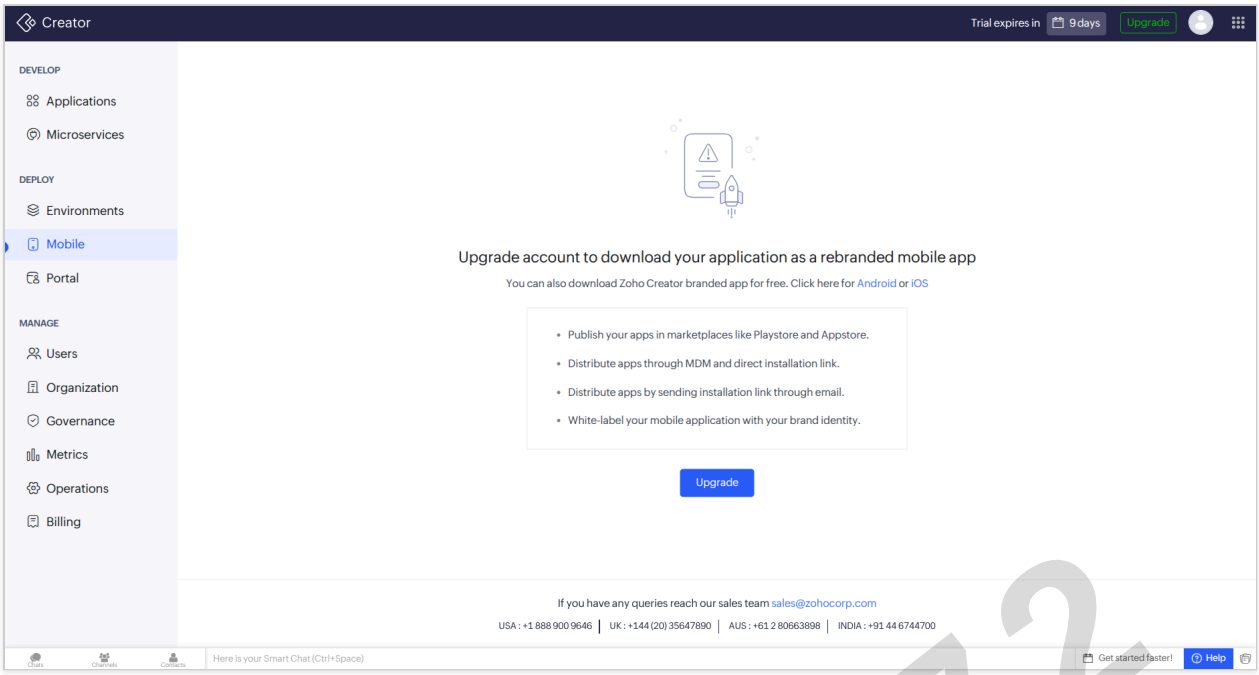


Figure 5: Mobile screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: A suite for customizing, white-labeling, and deploying applications for iOS and Android devices.

Purpose: Facilitates mobile accessibility by enabling direct distribution, MDM setup, or publication to app stores with custom branding.

Use Case: Generating a custom-branded APK for an internal application, allowing field staff to easily install and access it on company smartphones.

3.5 Portal

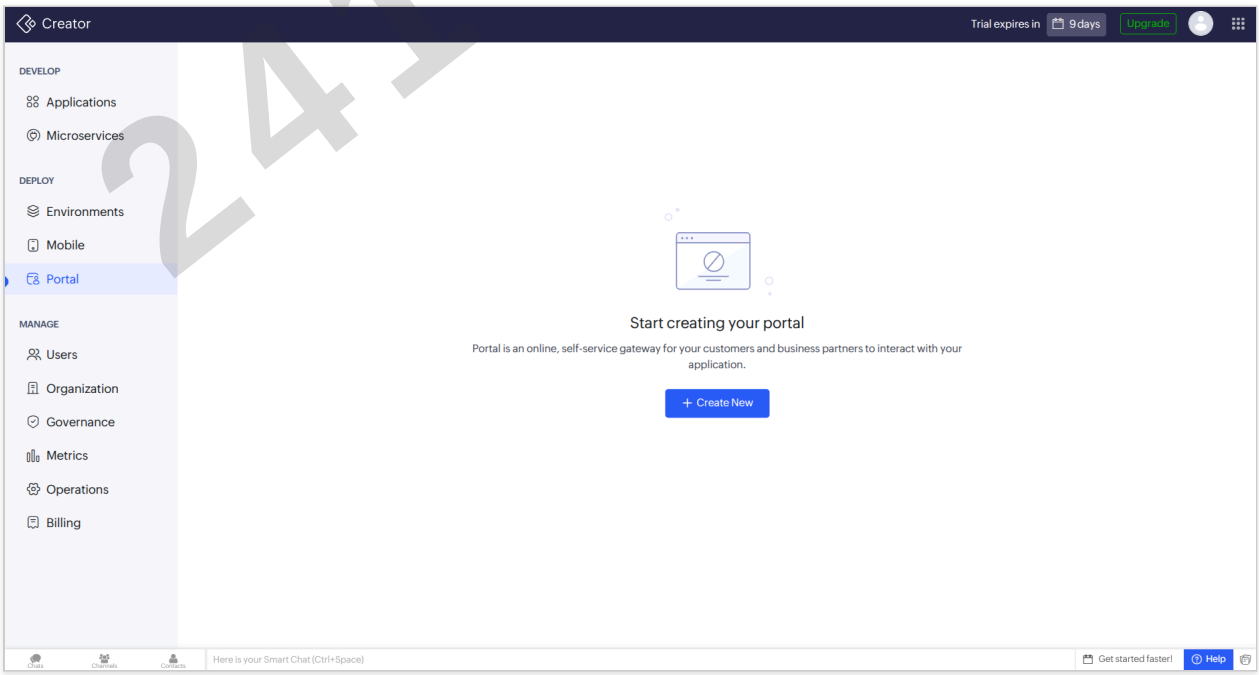


Figure 6: Portal screen in Zoho Creator

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Definition: A builder tool for constructing self-service web interfaces tailored for external users.

Purpose: Provides safe and constrained access for clients or external partners to perform tasks and view data without requiring internal organization credentials.

Use Case: Launching a parent portal where guardians can securely log in to review student performance reports and manage tuition payments.

3.6 Users

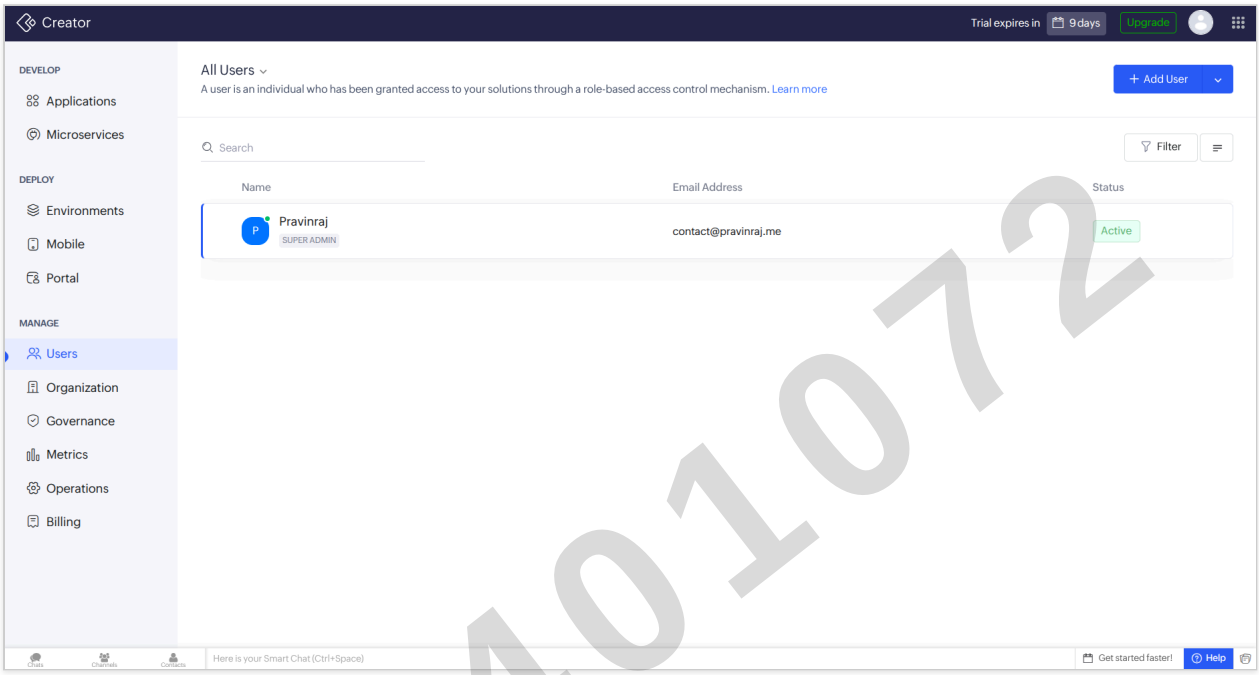


Figure 7: Users screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: The central interface for controlling user accounts and assigning permissions.

Purpose: Protects data integrity by implementing rigorous role-based access controls (RBAC) throughout the entire organization.

Use Case: Designating a team member as a Super Admin with comprehensive access, while limiting a new employee to view-only status.

3.7 Organization

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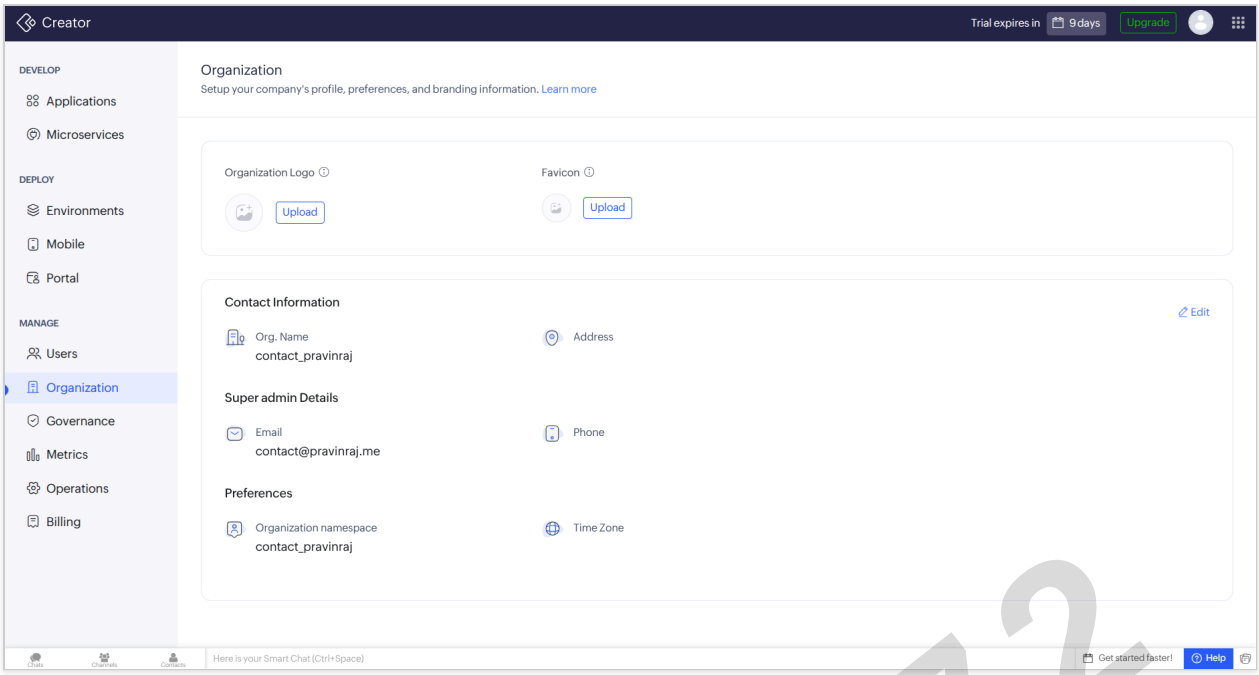


Figure 8: Organization screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: A settings panel for managing corporate identity, including logos, favicons, domain names, and regional time zones.

Purpose: Guarantees that all platform applications maintain a consistent brand presence and operate with correct regional configurations.

Use Case: Configuring the institutional logo and local time settings to ensure that automated system emails reflect the accurate timezone for all recipients.

3.8 Governance

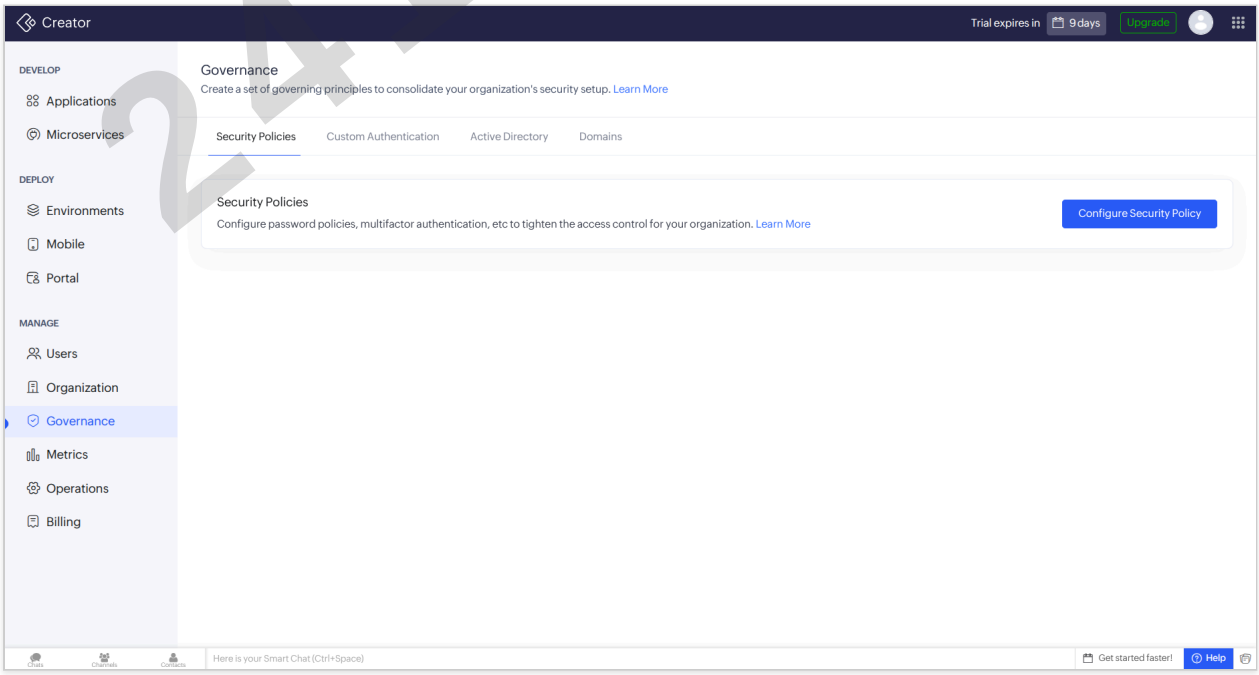


Figure 9: Governance screen in Zoho Creator

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Definition: A management hub for establishing security standards, custom authentication methods, and network rules.

Purpose: Ensures regulatory compliance and protects data by mandating password protocols and multi-factor authentication (MFA).

Use Case: Implementing mandatory Multi-Factor Authentication and integrating Single Sign-On (SSO) via Active Directory for secure staff authentication.

3.9 Metrics

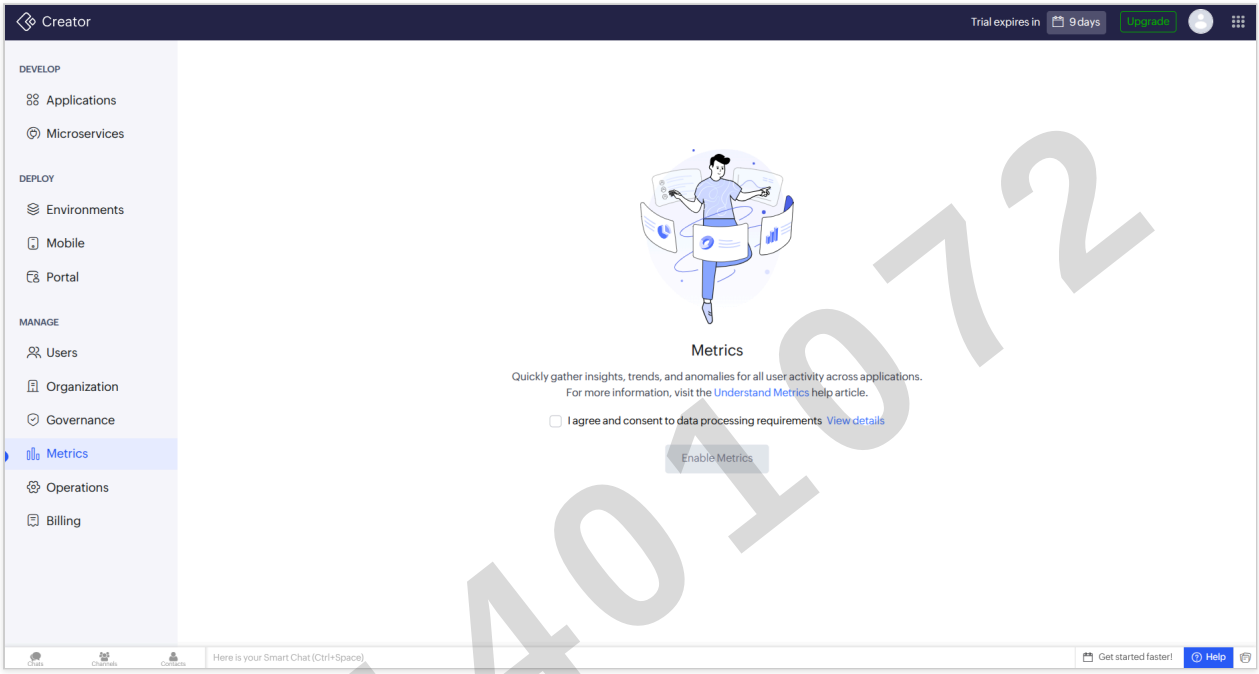


Figure 10: Metrics screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: An intelligence dashboard that monitors system activity, usage performance, and potential anomalies.

Purpose: Offers transparency into operational effectiveness and user engagement, supporting informed decisions for app optimization.

Use Case: Analyzing peak login times to identify when the server experiences the highest load from students submitting assignments.

3.10 Operations

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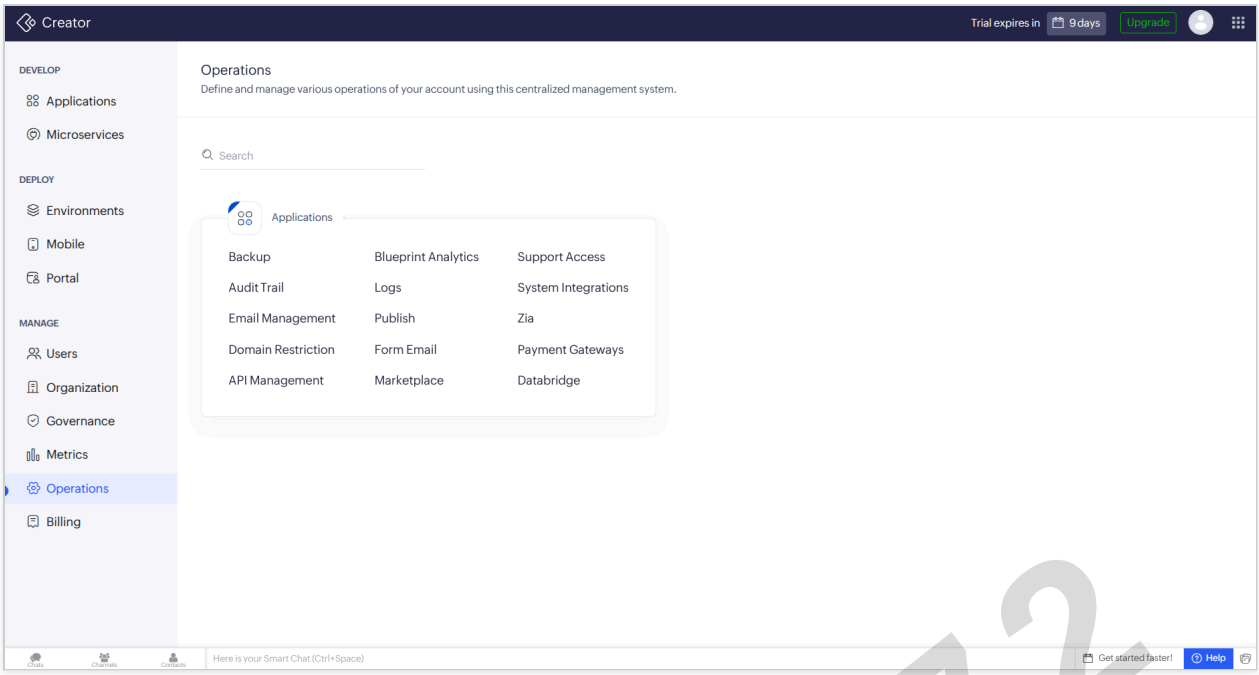


Figure 11: Operations screen in Zoho Creator

Definition: A unified administrative control panel providing access to system tools, maintenance logs, and payment integrations.

Purpose: Simplifies backend management by consolidating security audits, data backups, and external service connections into one interface.

Use Case: Linking Stripe via Payment Gateways for tuition processing, and utilizing Audit Trails to track modifications to student records.

3.11 Billing

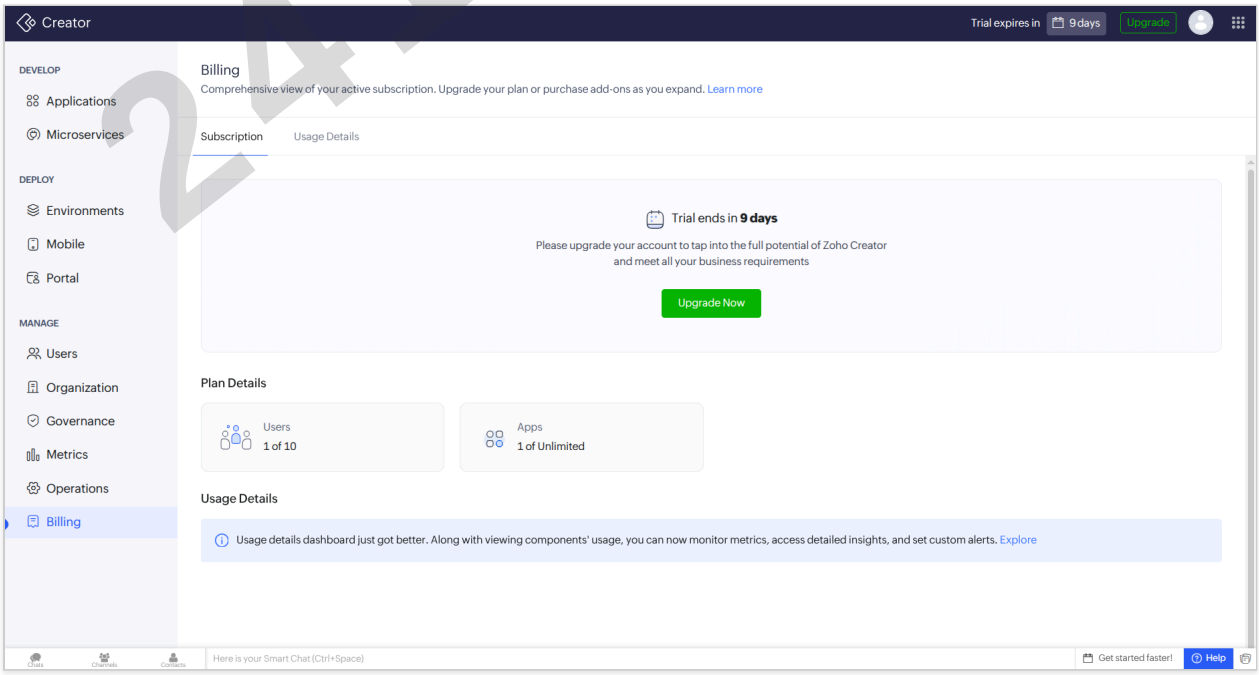


Figure 12: Billing screen in Zoho Creator

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Definition: The subscription portal for monitoring account tiers, licensing, and payment plans.

Purpose: Helps maintain service continuity by tracking usage limits and ensuring active subscription management for the organization.

Use Case: Upgrading the plan before the trial period concludes to gain access to mobile app branding and additional user seats.

4. Observations

- Zoho Creator organises its console into four logical groups: Solutions, Microservices, Deployment, and Management, which map directly onto the platform's layered low-code architecture.
- The Applications component is the core building block, while Microservices allow modular, independent functionality to be added to an app.
- Environments (Stage and Production) support a safe development-to-release workflow, mirroring traditional SDLC staging practices.
- Mobile and Portal components extend application access to mobile users and external stakeholders respectively, without additional development effort.
- Users, Organization, and Governance components together provide administrative control over access, structure, and compliance.
- Metrics, Operations, and Billing provide ongoing visibility into application performance, maintenance status, and subscription usage.

5. Conclusion

This experiment provided a structured walkthrough of the Zoho Creator platform's account setup process and its overall architecture. By exploring each of the platform's core components, from application creation to governance and billing, a clear understanding was formed of how Zoho Creator organises the full application lifecycle within a single low-code environment. This foundational understanding of the platform's structure and interface will support the hands-on development of business applications in the experiments that follow.

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